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KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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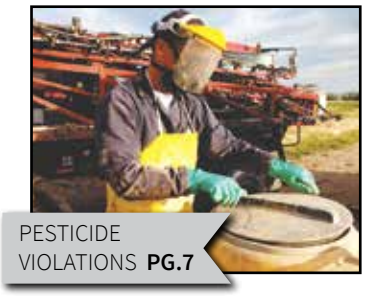
INSIDE



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From the Farm to the Board: Garrett Gilcrease Runs for Supervisor

Garrett Gilcrease has spent his life learning what it means to be accountable for a piece of land. His family has farmed in Kings County since 1883, four generations of decisions made in this soil, under this sun, in years both good and hard. Today, he farms almonds, grapes, and tomatoes and runs Pure Agronomics, helping growers across the Valley navigate crop and water management. He doesn't just understand the pressures facing local agriculture. He faces them himself every season.

This spring, Garrett is taking that experience into a different arena. He has announced his candidacy for the District 1 seat on the Kings County Board of Supervisors, and the Kings County Farm Bureau Board of Directors has voted to endorse his campaign.

That endorsement didn't come automatically. It came because we believe this moment matters.

Garrett joined the Farm Bureau Board of Directors in 2017 and has served in every leadership role since: Secretary/Treasurer, Vice President, and President since October 2025. His years on the board have coincided with some of the most consequential challenges local agriculture has faced, including groundwater implementation under SGMA, escalating regulatory pressure, and deepening uncertainty around water and land use policy. He has been in the room for those conversations. He has helped shape how we respond.

Now he's asking to take that work further.

At the Center of the Water Fight

To understand why this candidacy matters, it helps to understand what Kings County has been through with SGMA and what Garrett's role in that fight has been.

The Tulare Lake Subbasin, which covers the heart of Kings County, has been under state probationary status since April

Gilcrease continued on page 14

Local Groundwater Work Continues as State Engagement Returns to the Tulare Lake Subbasin

Across the Tulare Lake Subbasin, local agencies continue working to translate statewide groundwater requirements into practical solutions that reflect real basin conditions, agricultural realities, and community impacts.

by Julie Martella

A Return to Direct Engagement

February marked an important month across the Tulare Lake Subbasin as representatives from several Groundwater Sustainability Agencies (GSAs) met with the State Water Resources Control Board, signaling renewed direct engagement between State staff and local agencies responsible for implementing the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA).

Over the past year, direct communication between State Water Board staff and GSAs within the subbasin had largely ceased. During that time, local agencies continued advancing groundwater allocation policies, domestic well mitigation programs, subsidence management strategies, and required reporting efforts using previously issued guidance and formal evaluation materials.

TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN SGMA UPDATE

During this period, GSAs also looked to other California subbasins to understand how groundwater programs were being implemented elsewhere and which approaches had successfully advanced through State review. Local boards continued to make policy and funding decisions affecting landowners and communities while working to align local efforts with statewide expectations, despite limited opportunities for direct consultation.

In early 2026, State representatives resumed direct discussion with basin leadership. Local agencies welcomed the opportunity to reestablish dialogue as SGMA implementation continues moving from planning into long-term management.

State staff also communicated that recently adopted statewide Land Subsidence Best Management Practices may require portions of existing Groundwater Sustainability Plans to be revisited moving forward, reinforcing the importance of ongoing coordination between State oversight and local implementation.

SGMA continued on pg 5

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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SGMA Litigation Update: Supreme Court Closes One Door, Superior Court Fight Continues

The Supreme Court Has Spoken. The Fight Continues.

On February 13, the California Supreme Court declined to hear the Farm Bureau's petition challenging the Fifth District Court of Appeal's decision to reverse the preliminary injunction. That injunction had shielded Kings County growers from state fees and reporting requirements since September 2024. With the Supreme Court declining review, that protection is gone for now. The case has returned to Kings County Superior Court, where the remaining legal questions will be decided.

What Is Still Being Fought

The Supreme Court's denial narrows the case but does not end it. Several causes of action remain alive before the Superior Court, including the central argument that the State Water Resources Control Board exceeded its authority under SGMA and imposed sanctions improperly. The court also left open the question of whether the Water Board wrongly denied the "good actor" exemption to the Tri-County Water Authority and the Southwest Kings Groundwater Sustainability Agency, two agencies that were in compliance with SGMA requirements. Those questions will now be decided at trial.

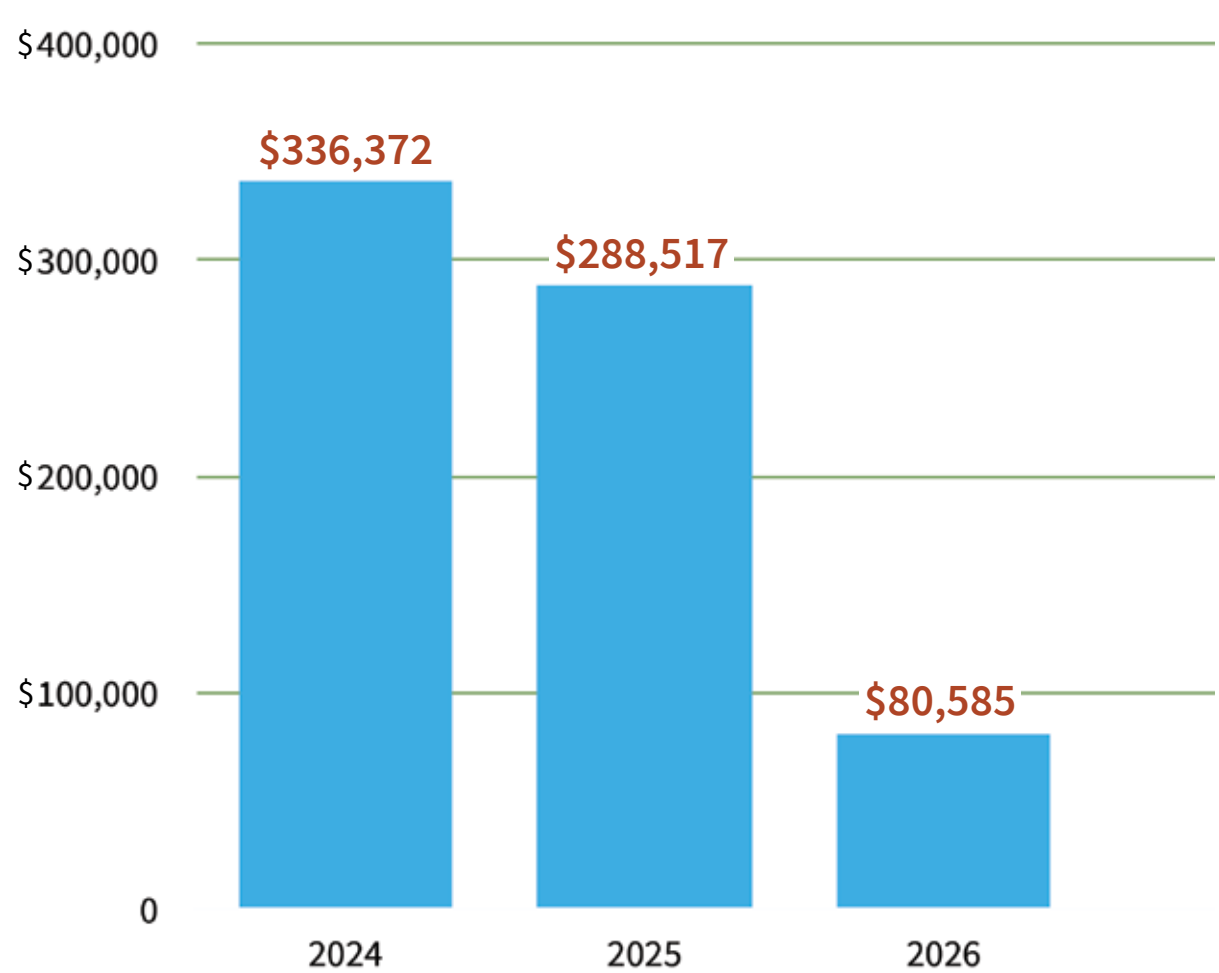
March 12: The Next Hearing

A hearing is scheduled for March 12 in Kings County Superior Court. The court will take up the opening briefs submitted in February and begin addressing the unresolved legal and procedural issues, including the State's position on back fees and reporting requirements. Farm Bureau representatives and legal counsel will be present. We will provide a full report on that hearing in the April issue.

What Members Should Do Now

If you received a postcard from the State Water Resources Control Board, save it. The reporting period listed runs from July 15, 2024 through September 30, 2025, with a stated deadline of May 1. The Farm Bureau has put the Attorney General on notice that retroactive fee collection may not be legally permissible and intends to challenge it. That challenge will be addressed through the ongoing litigation. In the meantime, keep your records organized and watch for further guidance. We will continue to keep you informed as the case moves forward.

Investment in SGMA Defense Litigation by Year



KCFB

KINGS edc

ECONOMIC IMPACT REPORT 2024

INTRODUCTION

Kings County agriculture remains a vital part of the local economy, fueling growth, creating jobs, and supporting community investment. This report emphasizes agriculture's contribution to the county's $7.7 billion GDP, its above-average wages, and its ripple effect across various industries. From supporting over 8,000 jobs to generating millions in property taxes, agriculture continues to anchor Kings County's economic stability and future growth.

AVERAGE ANNUAL WAGES FOR AG

$65,644[1]

AVERAGE ANNUAL ALL INDUSTRIES

$58,005[1]

AGRICULTURE WAGES ARE

13.2%

Higher than the average in Kings County

AG PAYS APPROXIMATELY $44.3 MILLION IN PROPERTY TAXES EACH YEAR[2]

- **22.65%** to the County, Fire Department, & Libraries
- **13.94%** to Rural Development Agency
- **6.19%** to the Cities
- **6.09%** to Special Districts

MULTIPLIER FOR EMPLOYMENT

1.47[1]

Indirect and Induced Job Creation

For every job in agriculture, about one and a half more jobs are created in other parts of the economy.

JOBS TOTAL IN AG

8,139[1]

JOB TOTAL ALL INDUSTRIES 53,281[1]

AG makes up aproximately **15%**

1 Source: JobsEQ®, http://www.chmuraecon.com/jobseq
2 Kings County Assessor's Office
Annual Wages, 2024 Q4. Employment 2024 Q4. Economic Impact-Multiplier 2024 Q4; GDP 2023.

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

AG NEWS IN BRIEF

Bureau of Reclamation Announces 15% Initial CVP Allocation, Drawing Sharp Criticism from Valley Farmers

On February 26, the Bureau of Reclamation announced an initial 15 percent water supply allocation for south-of-Delta Central Valley Project agricultural contractors, including Westlands Water District, which serves nearly 700 family-owned farms across a portion of Kings and Fresno counties. Valley growers, water managers, and members of Congress responded quickly, arguing the figure bears no relation to current conditions on the ground.

Westlands General Manager Allison Febbo stated that the allocation falls well short of what is needed given recent storms, improved snowpack, and increased reservoir storage. Congressmen Adam Gray and Jim Costa released a joint statement calling the allocation unjustified and offensive to San Joaquin Valley farmers, noting that the Trump administration had promised to deliver more water to the region. The State Water Project, operated separately by the California Department of Water Resources, is tracking toward a significantly higher allocation for its own contractors.

Initial CVP allocations are typically updated multiple times throughout the year as snowpack and runoff data are refined. Producers who depend on CVP deliveries should plan conservatively for the early season and watch for updated allocation announcements in the coming months. Growers with questions about how their water service contract is affected should contact their water district directly.

World Ag Expo Draws Over 100,000 to Tulare for 59th Annual Show

The 2026 World Ag Expo wrapped up its three-day run February 10–12 at the International Agri-Center in Tulare, drawing more than 100,000 attendees from all 50 states and 53 countries. The show featured 1,179 exhibitors spread across 2.6 million square feet of exhibit space, with agricultural technology and automation dominating exhibitor space and conversation on the floor.

CDFA Secretary Karen Ross attended opening ceremonies and participated in an on-site meeting of the State Board of Food and Agriculture focused on agricultural technology and workforce development. Two $10,000 "We Believe in Growing" scholarships were awarded to Kaedyn Plann and Tanner Verhoeven, both students from the five-county region of Madera, Fresno, Tulare, Kings, and Kern.

The Tulare Chamber of Commerce estimated the economic impact at more than $60 million for the county. Planning is already underway for the 60th World Ag Expo, scheduled for February 9–11, 2027. Potential exhibitors can request space beginning March 1, 2026, at worldagexpo.com.

USDA Opens $1 Billion Specialty Crop Relief Program — March 13 Deadline for California Growers

The U.S. Department of Agriculture has launched the Assistance for Specialty Crop Farmers (ASCF) Program, making $1 billion available in one-time bridge payments to producers of fruits, vegetables, tree nuts, dried fruits, and horticulture and nursery crops. The program is part of the broader $12 billion Farmer Bridge Assistance package announced last December and is specifically designed to address commodities not covered under the row crop-focused Farmer Bridge Assistance Program.

California growers have more at stake here than producers in most other states. Specialty crops account for the majority of the state's farm revenue, and the ASCF is aimed at offsetting losses tied to market disruptions, elevated input costs, persistent inflation, and unfair competition from foreign producers. Payments will be based on 2025 planted acres, and USDA has indicated commodity-specific payment rates will be released by the end of March. Crop insurance linkage will not be required to qualify.

Local growers need to act now: all producers must ensure their 2025 planted acreage is on file with their local USDA Farm Service Agency office no later than March 13, 2026. Miss that date and the payment window closes. Producers who have not previously worked with FSA should contact their local office now to confirm records are current. More information is available at fsa.usda.gov/fba.

Tariff Uncertainty Continues to Weigh on California's Export-Dependent Specialty Crops

Ongoing trade tensions and shifting federal tariff policy continue to create uncertainty for California's specialty crop producers, who depend heavily on export markets. The state ships approximately $24 billion in agricultural products overseas annually, with tree nuts, dairy, and wine among the leading categories. Mexico and Canada, the two largest destinations for U.S. agricultural exports, have both been subject to tariff actions and retaliatory measures in recent months.

California-specific concerns center on commodities where the state holds near-monopoly production. Nearly 80 percent of the world's almonds and a significant share of global pistachio supply come from California—crops that already faced retaliatory tariffs from China in previous trade disputes. A Yale Budget Lab analysis released February 20 estimated that current tariff policy is projected to cause a long-run decline of more than one percent in U.S. agricultural output, as manufacturing sector gains fail to offset losses in farming and other sectors.

For permanent crop producers—orchards and vineyards that cannot be easily idled—lost export market access is particularly difficult to absorb. California Farm Bureau and commodity organizations are tracking trade negotiations closely and pushing for market access protections. Growers should check in with their commodity boards regularly; policy in this area is moving fast and the details matter.

Egg Prices Decline Sharply as Flock Recovery Continues, But HPAI Vigilance Remains Essential

After more than a year of historically high egg prices driven by highly pathogenic avian influenza outbreaks, retail egg prices declined 5.3 percent from December 2025 to January 2026, according to USDA's Economic Research Service. On an annual basis, retail egg prices were 34.2 percent lower in January 2026 than they were a year prior, when the impact of repeated flock depopulations was still being felt across the market. USDA is forecasting a further 27 percent decline in egg prices across 2026 as the national laying flock continues to recover.

Those numbers reflect real recovery in biosecurity and flock repopulation. California's poultry producers absorbed some of the worst losses in the country during the outbreak years, with approximately 10.6 million laying hens and another 1 million table-egg pullets lost to HPAI statewide from 2022 through 2024. California's cage-free sourcing requirement made things worse: when supply tightened anywhere in the system, prices here moved faster than in most other markets.

None of that means biosecurity can ease up. HPAI outbreaks remain a risk through migratory bird season, and CDFA's elevated biosecurity expectations—including those extended for organic operations last month—remain in effect. Producers can request on-farm biosecurity assessments through USDA's Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service by emailing poultry.biosecurity@usda.gov or calling 844-820-2234. USDA shares up to 75 percent of the cost to address high-risk biosecurity concerns identified during those assessments.

Ag News in Brief is distributed by the Kings County Farm Bureau to its members for informational purposes only. Some stories may reference online content requiring website registration or subscription. The inclusion of any article, commentary, or editorial does not imply endorsement by the Kings County Farm Bureau. Views expressed are those of the original authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of KCFB. While we strive to share timely and relevant information, KCFB is not responsible for the accuracy, completeness, or consequences of reliance on any third-party content.

Brian Medeiros Joins Kings County Water District

By Liza Robertson

Motivated by a generational commitment to sustain local ag through strategic water management, Brian Medeiros has joined the Kings County Water District (KCWD) board of directors. While he had intended to run for the Division 4 seat this coming November, the appointment came in early February after the passing of his predecessor, Joe Freitas, in late 2025. He still plans to seek a full term on the ballot later this year, a decision fueled by a sense of responsibility to keep the area's farms intact.

L to R: Brian, Aidan, and Rui Medeiros

"I've been looking at the water district because a lot of our solutions as farmers are tied to surface water," he said. "That's the only place we're going to get some relief from the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA) constraints. My thought process was to get involved and help steer things in the best way possible for farmers and to help our community here continue."

Medeiros, who farms almonds, cotton, alfalfa, wheat and sorghum in Hanford, is motivated by a personal commitment to the future of the local ag industry. He wants to use his time on the KCWD board to find ways to balance the immediate needs of farms with the state's long-term sustainability mandates. He's also considering alternative solutions for farmers to utilize fallowed land in a way that affords them enough water to keep their most profitable crops in production.

"Unfortunately, a lot of us are going to be forced to fallow a lot of ground. I'm looking at options to use that land in a way that helps us have enough water for the crops we can farm. If you look back to the 1950s and '60s, everyone had some acreage that wasn't irrigated. Now, every last square inch is cultivated and farmed, but given the current constraints, that's not going to be realistic."

While much of his focus is on ensuring farmers have water for their crops, Medeiros is also thinking beyond the farm.

"I know the district isn't only here to serve farmers. It serves the community as a whole. We need to make sure that everyone who lives within the water district

Medeiros continued on page 11

SGMA Litigation continued from page 1

Understanding the Intent of SGMA

The Sustainable Groundwater Management Act was adopted in 2014 with a clear guiding principle: groundwater sustainability in California would be achieved through **local management supported by State oversight.**

Under SGMA, local Groundwater Sustainability Agencies were created so that decisions affecting water use, agriculture, communities, and infrastructure could be made by those closest to the land and to basin conditions. The State's role was designed to function as a backstop, stepping in only when sustainability goals were not being met.

This structure requires ongoing coordination. Local agencies must demonstrate measurable progress toward sustainability, while State regulators evaluate whether those efforts are sufficient to protect groundwater resources over time.

As implementation advances, tension can emerge when local agencies are actively developing policies while State expectations continue to evolve. The success of SGMA ultimately depends on consistent two-way communication between both levels of governance so that locally developed solutions can meet statewide sustainability requirements.

When Local Implementation Continued Without Direction

February's discussions underscored the conditions under which local agencies have been working as SGMA moves into implementation. Over the past year, direct communication between the State Water Board and the Tulare Lake Subbasin had ceased, even as local GSAs were required to continue advancing allocation policies, mitigation programs, and compliance actions.

During that period, agencies received little to no direct guidance from State staff. To move forward, GSAs reviewed actions taken in other California subbasins and aligned local decisions with approaches that had successfully advanced through State review elsewhere. Local boards therefore made significant policy and funding decisions affecting landowners and communities while working without confirmation that locally adopted approaches would ultimately meet State expectations.

For many agencies, February's renewed engagement marked an important step toward restoring the communication needed to support effective implementation under SGMA's locally driven framework.

Mid-Kings River GSA

The Mid-Kings River GSA focused this month on implementation efforts related to domestic well reliability and basin coordination.

The Board approved funding for a pilot Domestic Well Mitigation Program to address confirmed dry wells through either replacement drilling or, where feasible, connection to municipal systems. The Board also adopted an updated Domestic Well Mitigation Policy that expands eligibility considerations to include impacts from subsidence and water quality.

South Fork Kings GSA

South Fork Kings continued advancing subsidence management and groundwater accountability discussions during February.

The Advisory Committee reviewed two Subsidence Management Plan mapping alternatives that will move forward to the Board for additional consideration. These options reflect ongoing efforts to align locally observed groundwater conditions with emerging statewide subsidence guidance.

The Committee also discussed enforcement measures related to well registration, including proposed penalties for non-de minimis agricultural wells not registered prior to upcoming reporting deadlines. Early discussions also began regarding development of a standardized Well Metering Policy to support consistent groundwater measurement and reporting.

Southwest Kings GSA

Southwest Kings experienced an active and consequential policy month, advancing several groundwater management actions as the agency works toward implementation.

During a special meeting, the Board adopted a Groundwater Allocation Policy establishing an initial allocation of 0.33 acre-feet per acre. The policy also includes eligibility provisions requiring a minimum threshold of 100 acres for participation in the allocation program.

Board discussion reflected that the adopted framework represents a significant early implementation step and may continue evolving as additional data, stakeholder input, and regional coordination efforts move forward.

Tri-County Water Authority

Tri-County Water Authority discussions this month emphasized continued coordination among GSAs throughout the Tulare Lake Subbasin. Regional collaboration remains important as agencies work toward consistent implementation approaches while responding to both local groundwater conditions and statewide regulatory review.

El Rico GSA

El Rico GSA did not hold a meeting during February.

What Stakeholders Can Do Now

As groundwater management moves further into implementation, stakeholder awareness and participation remain important. Ensuring wells are properly registered, following allocation and subsidence discussions, and remaining engaged with local GSA meetings helps ensure local conditions continue to inform groundwater management decisions.

Looking Beyond Implementation

SGMA was designed to prioritize local groundwater management supported by State oversight. As implementation progresses in the Tulare Lake Subbasin, local agencies continue to work to demonstrate measurable progress toward sustainability while operating under increased regulatory oversight.

February's renewed engagement highlighted an important question shared across many agencies: how can local basins clearly demonstrate sufficient progress to fully return to locally directed management once additional oversight is triggered?

Across the Tulare Lake Subbasin, groundwater sustainability efforts continue to advance through local decision-making, regional coordination, and renewed dialogue with State partners charged with ensuring long-term resource protection.

Julie Martella is a Kings County farmer and consultant specializing in SGMA implementation, stakeholder communication, and rural community engagement within the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

SGMA DEFENSE FUND
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Join the Fight!

THIS EFFORT HAS SAVED GROWERS IN THE TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN $40-$60/ACRE AND $300/WELL SINCE KCFB WAS ISSUED A PRELIMINARY INJUNCTION.

CONTRIBUTE $15/ACRE TO THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Top 10 Pesticide Violations

Each year the California Department of Pesticide Regulation (CDPR) publishes a list of the Top 10 Pesticide Violations throughout the state of California. This article will address and briefly describe the top 10 violations in the state for the year 2024. Kings County focuses on training and outreach to all of our growers and businesses, so we do not necessarily mirror those violations of the CDPR's list, but we do share the top three non-compliances for 2024.

NUMBER 10 - Handler Decontamination Facilities: Violation 3CCR 6734 is Handler Decontamination Facilities. Decontamination facilities must supply workers with paper towels, water and soap. Paper towels provided must be single use. A minimum of 3 gallons of water per person is required at the start of every day. There is no substitution for soap. These facilities must be at the mix/load site, which must be within ¼ mile of the application site. Emergency eyewash must be provided for each employee if eyewear is required by labeling, regulation, permit conditions, or if using a closed system. There must be at least one pint of water with the applicator or in the application vehicle at all times. There must also be an emergency eyewash station located at the mix/load site to gently rinse eyes for 15 minutes. The most frequent non-compliances are not having a decontamination site at the mix/load site, not having a mix/load site location within ¼ mile and handlers substituting wet towelettes for soap and water.

NUMBER 9 – Availability of Labeling: Availability of Labeling at Use Site falls under 3CCR 6602. All applicators are required to have a copy of the label for all pesticides being applied with them when at the application site.

NUMBER 8 - Hazard Communication for Fieldworkers: Another common violation is Hazard Communication for Fieldworkers 3CCR 6761. A grower is required to post a completed Pesticide Safety Information Series (PSIS) A-9 pamphlet at a worksite or a central location where employees start their day. This information is also required to be posted at all permanent decontamination facilities and temporary decontamination facilities servicing 11 or more field workers. This form includes medical information of where they can go to receive medical care and where to locate Application Specific Information (ASI) for the grower they are working for. It is important to note that all changes in medical information must be updated on the forms within 24 hours of the change. Updating and informing employees of where this form is located are the most frequent violations.

NUMBER 7 – Proper Application Specific Information: ASI for Fieldworkers 3CCR 6761.1 is another violation. ASI is information made available to workers about what pesticides have been applied to the site they are working in. This must be displayed in a central location, and must specify crop and site treated, date and time the application started and finished, Re-Entry Interval (REI), what pesticide was used, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) registration number and the active ingredient in the pesticide. The best example of an ASI would be a Pesticide Use Report (PUR). ASI must also be retained for two years. The most common issues for this regulation are displaying an ASI with missing information and not retaining records for two years.

NUMBER 6 - Adequate Handler Training: This violation falls under Handler Training in the California Code of Regulations Title 3 Food and Agriculture (3CCR) 6724. The regulation states that an employer must provide training for all employees who handle pesticides. An employer must have a training program that goes over all of the specific categories. These categories include but are not limited to Personal Protective Equipment (PPE), safety requirements, hazards of pesticides and their use, signs and symptoms of exposure, decontamination, and more. The most common employer offenses are not retaining two years of training records and not including all pesticides that the employee will be handling. Kings County Department of Agriculture provides a Handler Training that covers pesticide handler training categories and can help with pesticide specific information.

NUMBER 5 – Container Labeling: Another common issue is Service Container Labeling 3CCR 6678. All service containers are required to contain a label providing name and address of the responsible person, company, identity of the pesticide it is containing. Labeling must also include the signal word, i.e. caution, warning, danger, for the pesticide. The only exemption from this is a grower on their own property. This exemption does not include the grower traveling on public rights-of-ways.

NUMBER 4 – Registration: Registration in the County is Food and Agricultural Code (FAC) 11732. Anyone who intends to advertise, solicit, or operate as a pest control business in California must register in each county they do business.

NUMBER 3 – Emergency Medical Care: Emergency Medical Care is a non-compliance of 3CCR 6726. Emergency medical care must be planned in advance for employees that handle pesticides. The name, address, and phone number of the medical care facility must be posted at the worksite or on the vehicle the employee is using for applications. Employees must be taken for medical care immediately when a pesticide related illness or exposure is suspected. Not taking an employee immediately after exposure or injury for medical care and missing information or posting are two significant violations found.

NUMBER 2 - Personal Protection Equipment (PPE): PPE falls under 3CCR 6738. It is the employer's responsibility to provide an employee with the required PPE for each day of work. Employers are also responsible for daily inspection, cleaning and repair of the equipment. They must provide a place to keep all PPE separate

Pesticide Violations continued on page 13

Put earnings back in your pocket with competitive borrowing rates and an annual cash dividend through our Patronage Program.

In 2025, AgWest paid the equivalent of 1.25% of eligible average daily loan balances back to our customer-owners.

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Below-Average Snowpack Raises Water Supply Concerns for 2026 Irrigation Season

March 2026 | Water Resources & Agricultural Outlook

Statewide Snowpack Remains Well Below Average

Despite a promising start to California's wet season and a series of late December storms, the state's mountain snowpack remains significantly below average heading into spring. The Sierra Nevada snowpack, which provides roughly 30 percent of the state's annual water supply through spring runoff, has been lagging behind historical medians across central and southern mountain ranges. State officials reported the snowpack at approximately 59 percent of average by the end of January.

Reservoir levels remain reasonably strong across much of the state, and the U.S. Drought Monitor reported no drought conditions anywhere in California in mid-January following a wet fall. However, water managers caution that late-season snowpack levels, not current reservoir storage, will ultimately determine summer surface water availability for irrigation. Full reservoirs don't offset a weak snowpack for growers who depend on spring and summer runoff deliveries.

Late February storms brought additional snowfall to the upper elevations, but a storm cycle or two is unlikely to close the gap entirely, and the window for meaningful accumulation narrows as temperatures rise in March and April. Growers dependent on surface water should monitor State Water Project (SWP) and Central Valley Project (CVP) allocation announcements closely as the season progresses.

How Snowpack Translates to Water Allocations

Sierra snowpack and water allocations don't track each other cleanly, and the timing of spring warming is as important as total accumulation. A slow melt allows water to move steadily into reservoirs and canals; a rapid warm-up generates runoff that overwhelms conveyance capacity and forces operators to release water downstream to manage flood risk. Either way, a snowpack deficit at the start of the melt season means less total water to allocate.

The U.S. Bureau of Reclamation's initial 2026 CVP water service contractor allocation is due out in early March and will be the first hard number growers have to work with. In below-average snowpack years, initial allocations are set conservatively and adjusted upward only if late-season precipitation materializes. Growers should base acreage and crop mix decisions on the initial allocation rather than counting on upward revisions.

Implications for Kings County Growers

Kings County is one of the most water-dependent agricultural counties in California. The county's $1.6 billion farm economy runs on cotton, pistachios, almonds, tomatoes, silage corn, and a range of field crops, all of which require reliable irrigation. That water comes from three places: surface water through CVP and Kings River rights, local groundwater, and irrigation districts that manage a blend of both. When snowpack falls short, all three are affected.

Surface water contractors in Kings County, including Tulare Lake Basin Water Storage District, Kings River Water Association member districts, and CVP con-

Snowpack continued on page 14

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

SUPPORTING FARMERS IN PORTIONS OF **FRESNO, KINGS, AND TULARE COUNTIES**

WELLUP Program

EKRCD's WELLUP program provides farmers in its region and surrounding areas with the technical support to evaluate their farm's water supply health and plan for drought impacts and water shortages.

Program Benefits

Pump Efficiency Testing

- FREE pump tests for eligible producers.
- Up to 6 tests per producer (Non-SDFR).
- Up to 10 tests per producer (SDFR*).
- Available regardless of acreage or farm size.

Program Eligibility

To qualify for WELLUP submit an intake form.

Who can apply?

Farmers and producers in Fresno, Kings, and Tulare Counties.

Special incentives are available for Socially Disadvantaged Farmers & Ranchers (SDFR).

ekrcd.org **Call us at: 559.309.4030**

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Medeiros continued from page 5

can continue to have clean, safe, reliable water. I want to connect the whole community to water, because water isn't just a farmer problem."

Medeiros is cautious and wants to first gain a better understanding of how the KCWD functions before he acts on decisions that will have a lasting impact.

"I want to learn everything that I can and need to know before I start pushing buttons. It would be foolish to come into this role thinking I have all the answers to the issues we're facing. I know there are a lot of things the district can do to keep as many people farming as we can instead of letting it go. A lot of them cost a lot of money, so we need to keep that in mind."

He is specifically concerned with finding a way to extend the number of days farmers have access to surface water.

"My desire to serve is because I want to figure out a way to increase the days we have water. From my personal experience, we've lost 15 to 20 days of runtime per irrigation season over the last 20 years. My goal would be to make it so a farmer can irrigate a crop from start to finish on surface water. If we can do that, then we can succeed as farmers in this area."

Medeiros' involvement in local water governance and issues is well-established. He's on the board of the Last Chance Water Ditch Company, where he is treasurer and assists with the company's equipment and system improvements.

"I'm a stockholder at the ditch company, and I represent the minority stockholders in the service area. I don't represent the water district," said Medeiros when asked if he would maintain his seat even as he begins his new KCWD role.

He is also on the Mid-Kings River Groundwater Sustainability Agency's (GSA) advisory committee. He was appointed to this group by the Kings County Board of Supervisors, who now serve as the local GSA's board of directors, along with a representative from the City of Hanford, rather than the KCWD board, which previously managed the agency. The committee was created in response to pressure from many, including the Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB), for greater transparency and the need for input from landowners about groundwater sustainability.

Medeiros is firm in his belief that the best way to manage the impacts of SGMA is to have the water district and the GSA work side-by-side.

"I personally believe that having the water district operate in conjunction with the GSA is 100 percent necessary. There are a lot of reasons to argue yes, and no, about whether the water district should have been managing the GSA originally. As farmers, we need to be involved in all of it so we can live with the decisions coming out of it in the end; which is why I believe being involved in both the ditch company and water district is important."

Medeiros says having an understanding of the ditch side and the district side helps him see the whole picture.

"I see bringing my experience from both sides as a good way to form a farmer's viewpoint and try to steer things in a way where we can try to get as much benefit as possible. Serving on the water district means having the opportunity to help a larger area and take the needs of all the ditch companies into account. The last thing I want to see is increased subsidence and diminished water flows."

Medeiros sees a path for the water district's role to evolve as it relates to Groundwater Sustainability Plan (GSP) implementation and would like to see the district help farmers get as much water from the dam to their fields as efficiently as possible.

"There's only so much water in the state to have, so we need to come up with all the options we can. That will get us to a point where we can succeed in the future. I also know that the state is moving the goal post on the GSAs continually and I'd like to see us find a way to set that goal post so we know exactly what we need to achieve."

Medeiros is driven by a vision for the future of his own family's farm and a sense of commitment to the long-term viability of both the community and agriculture in the area.

"My goal is not to continue a dying heritage, but to provide an opportunity for our youth to come into agriculture if they want to make their livelihoods in it. My son says he wants to be a farmer just like me and my dad. Am I going to succeed? I don't know, but I'm at least trying—but none of it is possible if we don't have water."

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

By Kings County Sheriff's Office – Rural Crimes Unit

Kings County Ag community,

During the month of January and February, the Rural Crimes Unit has been very busy investigating ag equipment thefts in the Corcoran area. The Kings County Sheriff's Office took (3) reports of equipment stolen to include, a John Deere 310J backhoe, a CAT 420F backhoe, and a CAT 926M loader. We also assisted Corcoran Police with (4) equipment thefts within Corcoran city limits which included, a CASE 570N tractor, (2) Bobcat skid steers, and a CASE 580 backhoe. The Rural Crimes Unit and Corcoran Police Department were able to recover six of the seven stolen items and return them to their rightful owners valued at approximately $410,000.

On February 10th, Kings County Sheriff's Office (KCSO) Deputies were dispatched to the 5700 block of Niles Ave in Corcoran regarding a stolen white Chevy Silverado work truck. Approximately one hour later, a Deputy located the stolen vehicle parked within Corcoran city limits. The Rural Crimes Unit Detectives conducted surveillance on the vehicle and ultimately the suspect, who was later identified as Luciano Navarro, got into the vehicle and drove off. We followed the vehicle for a few blocks until KCSO Deputies attempted to pull over the vehicle. Luciano refused to pull over and a pursuit was initiated. The pursuit led us outside of Corcoran City limits and into the county. The pursuit lasted for approximately one hour before Luciano crashed into an embankment and he fled into a canal. Luciano was arrested and taken into custody without further incident. Luciano was later interviewed and admitted to stealing all but one of the above-mentioned equipment and also admitted to being involved in a pursuit with Corcoran PD a few days earlier. Luciano was then transported to the Kings County Jail.

This month California Highway Patrol took (2) stolen trailer thefts from ag related businesses. The first trailer was described as a utility trailer stolen from the area of Houston Ave and 15th Avenue. The other trailer was described as a dump trailer which was taken from the area of Highway 43 near the Kings River. Both victims in these cases reached out to us to ask if we could assist in locating their trailers. A couple days after the utility trailer was stolen the victim reached out to our unit and advised he had located his trailer for sale on Facebook Marketplace. We notified the seller we were interested in purchasing the trailer and set up a location to meet the following day. Once we arrived, we verified the trailer was in fact the victim's trailer and a male and female subject were arrested.The Rural Crimes Unit conducted further investigation into the stolen dump trailer and were able to identify the pickup truck towing the trailer. This led us to Woodlake where we were able to locate the trailer parked on a property. The registered owner of the truck was not home, but we spoke to him by phone. He explained he had bought the trailer on Facebook and paid cash for it. It appears to us he was not aware the trailer was stolen and he admitted he thought he was getting a good deal. We recovered the trailer and towed it back to the rightful owner's property.

As many of you are aware the animal rights group, Direct Action Everywhere (DXE), were in our county on Saturday, February 21st, protesting at Grimmius Cattle Company. There was a total of approximately 20-25 vehicles, and we estimated approximately 40-50 people there. DXE members parked on the shoulder of the road on 6th Ave, just south of Kansas Ave, and some members held up banners and expressed their concerns through amplified speakers. They also launched a drone over the calf hutches on the facility, and we assume they took photos and videos later to post on their webpage. The group was there for about 2 hours and then left and headed to Tulare County to protest at Grimmius Cattle's other heifer ranch. We were in close contact with Tulare County Rural Crimes Unit during both protests and there was no criminal behavior committed at either site.

We have been receiving calls from the ag community with questions regarding drone usage above privately owned property. The most common question is: **Can I shoot down a drone if it is over my property?** The answer is **NO**. According to the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) website it states, "It's illegal under federal law to shoot at an aircraft. A private citizen shooting at any aircraft – including unmanned aircraft – poses a significant safety hazard. An unmanned aircraft hit by gunfire could crash, causing damage to persons or property on the ground, or it could collide with other objects in the air. Shooting at an unmanned aircraft could result in a civil penalty from the FAA and/or criminal charges from federal, state or local law enforcement." It is a federal felony under 18 U.S.C 32 (Aircraft Sabotage Act) which can lead to up to 20 years in federal prison and you may face civil penalties and fines from the FAA reaching $100,000. The above-mentioned law does not specify what minimum height a drone operator can fly at specifically, but if the drone is low enough to harass animals we would request you notify local law enforcement.

We also ask the ag community to continue to monitor any unusual activity near your facilities. If you see any suspicious vehicles parked near your property we ask you to take a photo or video of the vehicle from a safe distance if possible. If you are able to get a license plate number for us that is crucial for our investigations.

Lastly, I would like to introduce our newest member to the Rural Crimes Unit. Detective Bernardo has been employed by the Kings County Sheriff's Office patrol division since 2019 and brings agriculture related experience to our unit. We are excited to have him join our unit and he is looking forward to meeting the ag community.

If you have any questions regarding ag related crimes or questions regarding DXE, please contact the Kings County Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit.

Detective Santos: (559) 904-6893
Detective Estrada: (559 212-7512
Detective Bernardo: (559) 589-3535
Investigator Ward: (559) 280-5441

We appreciate the continued cooperation of the agricultural community and encourage the prompt reporting of any suspicious activity.

Pesticide Violations continued from page 7

from personal clothing and in a clean and pesticide free area. Employers should verify that PPE is used correctly and for the intended use. Using PPE that is damaged or contaminated or not being used for its intended purpose are the two major issues found.

NUMBER 1 - Labeling/Permit Conditions: Labeling/Permit Condition is FAC 12793. The most common violations found throughout the state is not following the application requirements listed on the pesticide product label and applying pesticides to sites or crops that are not listed on the pesticide label.

Non-compliances on any inspection can lead to enforcement actions including fines. The best way to avoid a non-compliance is to make sure you are following the labels, laws, and regulations. Read the labels, fill out your paperwork correctly, train your employees on all the pesticides you apply, and make sure you provide them with the proper equipment to keep them safe. Our office provides training classes and compliance audits to assist in determining areas which may need improvement for all growers and businesses. Audits can be requested at any time prior to an inspection.

If you have any questions, call the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's Office at (559) 852-2830.

Snowpack continued from page 9

tractors served through Friant Division deliveries, face the most direct exposure. In years when snowpack falls below 60 percent of average, as it currently stands, Friant contractors have historically seen initial allocations in the Class 1 tier reduced significantly, sometimes to as little as 25 to 50 percent of contract quantities, with Class 2 allocations curtailed further or eliminated entirely. Growers relying on Friant water for permanent crops such as pistachios and almonds face particularly difficult decisions when allocations arrive at those levels, as these trees cannot simply be fallowed without long-term yield and tree health consequences.

For Kings County growers with Kings River rights, the picture is somewhat different but no less uncertain. The Kings River is an unregulated system in the sense that it does not receive CVP or SWP project water. Its flows are driven directly by snowmelt and local runoff from the Kings River watershed. Pine Flat Reservoir, operated by the Army Corps of Engineers on the Kings River, entered the season in strong condition, providing a buffer. However, with snowpack in the Kings River watershed also running below average, total inflow projections for the spring and summer are subdued. Water masters managing river distribution will be watching snowpack closely through March.

Groundwater serves as a fallback for many Kings County operations, particularly those within GSA service areas operating under Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA) compliance plans. In wet years with strong surface water deliveries, growers bank groundwater and pull less from the aquifer. When surface water runs short, that equation flips: pumping demand spikes at the same time GSA-mandated extraction limits cap how much producers can draw. Kings County growers already navigating SGMA restrictions should coordinate with their GSA and water manager now to understand available groundwater volumes before committing to full acreage this spring.

What Kings County Growers Should Do Now

Plan conservatively. Water supply forecasts will be revised through the spring, but waiting for certainty before making acreage and input decisions is expensive. Growers should have irrigation plans ready for multiple allocation levels: 25, 50, and 75 percent of contract quantity. Growers should know in advance which fields or crops would be first candidates for deficit irrigation or fallowing if supplies come in at the low end.

Permanent crop operators should check soil moisture early and audit drip and micro-irrigation systems for efficiency. Deferred maintenance on irrigation infrastructure should be handled before the season starts. Getting pre-irrigation right, using available soil moisture storage rather than running unnecessary water, cuts in-season demand without sacrificing yield.

Annual crop producers have more options. Those weighing water-intensive field crops like cotton or silage corn should look hard at fallowing marginal acreage or shifting to lower-water crops where the rotation allows. Water transfers are worth exploring as well. Unused surface water allocations can be sold on the water market, which may pencil out better than producing a crop at a loss.

Growers participating in Kings County Farm Bureau water management programs or working with the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's office should watch for updated guidance as state and federal allocation announcements come out. DWR updates snowpack and runoff forecasts regularly through its website, and the Bureau of Reclamation posts CVP allocation updates as conditions change. Keeping up with those numbers over the next 60 to 90 days matters more than usual this year.

Looking Ahead

This isn't a crisis year. Not yet. Reservoirs are in decent shape, no drought designations are on the books, and more storms are possible. The danger is that strong reservoir storage gets read as a sign that the water year is fine overall, when the snowpack deficit is a real shortfall that may not be recovered by the time demand peaks in June and July.

Kings County growers have managed short water years before, and the institutional knowledge to do it again is there, in the irrigation districts, the water agencies, and on the farms. The ones who come through it best are generally those who get ahead of the decisions rather than waiting to see how bad it gets. April is too late to start those conversations.

Gilcrease continued from page 1

2024, when the California State Water Resources Control Board intervened after local groundwater agencies failed to deliver an acceptable sustainability plan. It was a historic and consequential action, the first time the state had ever placed a subbasin in probation, and it landed squarely on the backs of farmers who suddenly faced well registration fees, flow meter requirements, and extraction charges they had never anticipated.

His home ranch sits at the northern tip of the Tulare Lake Subbasin. He was not a bystander during this crisis. He was one of its most consistent and outspoken voices for transparency, accountability, and grower involvement.

When the original Mid-Kings River GSA came under fire for excluding growers from its planning process, proposing fees without stakeholder input, and ultimately refusing to sign on to a coordinated groundwater plan before the state's probationary hearing, Garrett and the Farm Bureau were among those demanding answers and accountability. "The train is coming at us with SGMA," he said at the time. "We need an engaged board that is willing to figure out the problem, who will work within the JPA and SGMA to allow growers to farm as much as humanly possible as long as they can into the future. You can't figure out something with the state if your local house isn't in order."

After the original Mid-Kings GSA effectively collapsed in the summer of 2024, when the Kings County Water District withdrew from the agency and board members resigned, the County stepped in to reconstitute it from the ground up. A key reform in the rebuilt agency was the creation of an 11-member stakeholder advisory committee designed to bridge the gap between policymakers and the landowners they serve. Garrett was appointed to represent District 1 on that committee and was subsequently chosen to serve as its Chairman.

It is a role that carries real weight. The advisory committee exists because growers fought for it, because the absence of that kind of structured grower involvement was one of the central failures of the original agency. Garrett now chairs the body that was created to ensure those failures are not repeated.

Why the Board of Supervisors Matters

The Board of Supervisors is not a distant body. It shapes land use decisions, infrastructure investment, public safety priorities, and how state mandates get implemented at the local level. For a county whose economy runs on production agriculture, that influence is not abstract. It shows up in every permit, every road, every drainage project, every local implementation plan. Having someone on that board who understands agriculture from the inside is not a luxury. It's a practical necessity.

That connection between county governance and water policy is not theoretical. The reconstituted Mid-Kings GSA board is now composed of Kings County Supervisors. What happens at the county level shapes what happens with groundwater. Garrett understands this better than most. He has watched it play out in real time, and he has been part of the effort to get it right.

A Changing of the Guard

This race also marks the end of a long chapter for District 1. Supervisor Joe Neves, whose tenure dates to 1994, is retiring. He has been a reliable advocate for local control and a steady presence through periods of real difficulty. His endorsement of Garrett reflects his belief that the district will remain in capable, grounded hands. We share that belief, and we are deeply grateful for Supervisor Neves' years of service to this community.

District 1, which includes Lemoore, Stratford, and the rural communities surrounding them, is agricultural country. The people who live and work there understand that county decisions have real consequences for farming families, and they deserve representation that understands that too. As Garrett has said himself: "I'm stepping up to ensure Kings County stays strong for the next generation."

Our Endorsement

Garrett's decision to run is a statement that agriculture should not just respond to policy, but help write it. We are proud of the leader he has become within this organization, and we are confident he will bring the same clarity and commitment to the Board of Supervisors.

"When you consider his farming background, his leadership within the Farm Bureau, and his role as Chairman of the GSA Stakeholder Committee, Garrett is arguably the most informed person in Kings County on what we believe is the most consequential challenge this county faces, now and for the foreseeable future. Water is not just an agricultural problem. It is a county-wide problem. And Garrett understands it as well as anyone."

— Chad Souza, Vice President, Kings County Farm Bureau

Farm Life will continue to keep members informed as this campaign develops. Kings County agriculture has fought hard to have a seat at the table. Garrett Gilcrease is how we keep it.

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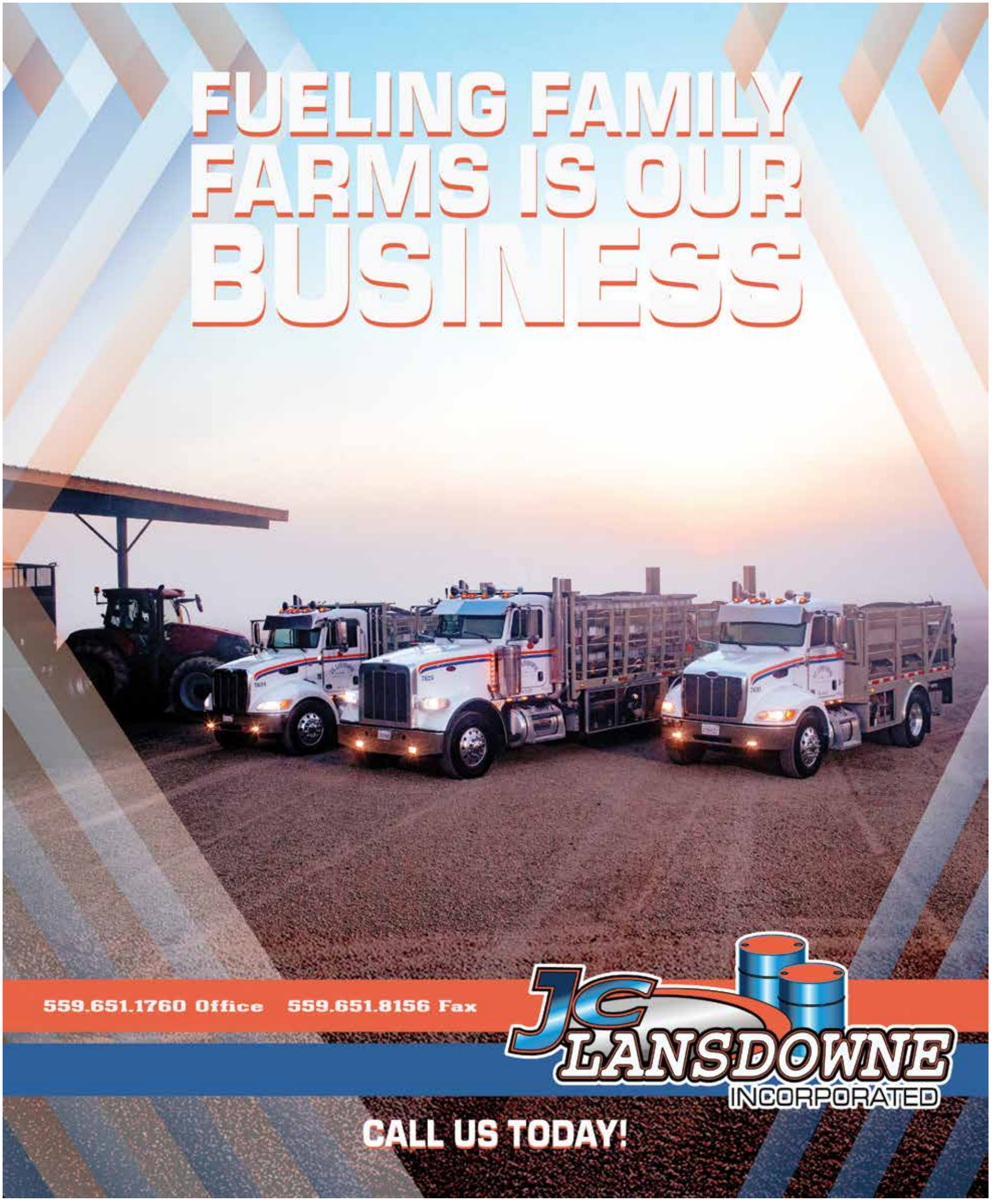
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